this difficult period.' He ended the letter wishing the employees and their families a very happy Diwali. It was a touching recognition of their support for the company and an acknowledgement that their individual contributions did not go unrecognized.

Nair, however, continued to issue press statements to portray the management in poor light. He issued a statement on 13 October accusing TELCO of refusing to talk with the TKS. Ratan did not remain silent. The next day, he held a press conference and clarified that Nair's intransigence had led to the breakdown of the talks called at the behest of the chief minister. In the statement, the management reiterated that 'the doors of Telco Pune are always open for a dialogue with the legally elected workers' representatives of the Telco Kamgar Sanghatana (TKS)'.

The management's strategy had a salutary impact on the functioning of the plants. More workers started reporting for duty. The production, which had nearly come to a standstill, crossed 70 per cent of the production level achieved during the corresponding period of the previous year.

It was a personal victory for Ratan. Not many had thought he would survive the brush with Nair, a popular leader who had powerful supporters both within and outside the Tata Group.

The unassuming Ratan, however, turned out to be a sharper strategist. Ultimately, it was Nair who had to withdraw all his demands unconditionally, resulting in 'the tremendous loss of its [TKS's] image and bargaining power' of its leader. Even the union's two main demands—reinstatement of the workers who had been dismissed since 1982 and rescinding of the 'no work, no pay' order, which they had maintained that they would not 'compromise at any cost'—had to be given up, commented a leading newspaper. This put the prospects of the president of the TKS, Jaisingh Powar, and its general secretary, Mahendra Salvi, of being taken back by the company, in jeopardy. TELCO ended up conceding next to nothing after Chief Minister Pawar warned the agitating workers that unless they withdrew the strike immediately, they would no longer be entertained.

Through his sincerity of purpose and equanimity, Ratan won the support of the workers, the political leadership of the country, and the press. And the collapse of the unrest that had drawn parallels with the Bombay Textile Strike of 1982 dealt a severe blow to militant trade unionism. More than anything else, it enhanced Ratan's reputation as a strong leader who feared little.